



Moments to remember: RCB's players and support staff celebrate with the IPL trophy after a successful title defence.

VIJAY SONEJI & PTI

Phil Salt blew teams away in the PowerPlay. Devdutt Padikkal provided fluency and stability at the top, while there were evenings when Rajat Patidar took charge through the middle overs, or Tim David arrived late to finish the job.

Over two months, contributions came from almost every corner of the dressing room. For years, RCB's fortunes had often been tied too closely to Kohli. If he scored heavily, the team usually prospered. If he failed, anxiety often followed. This season, that dependency finally seemed to loosen.

Kohli remained the cornerstone, finishing with 675 runs and once again demonstrating why he remains among the most dependable batters in the game. But support arrived from every direction.

Then there was Patidar.

He does not fit the conventional image of a captain. He is not animated on the field. He does not deliver theatrical speeches. His reactions rarely change regardless of the situation. Throughout the season, however, he exuded a quiet authority that seemed to resonate with the dressing room.

The impact became increasingly visible as the tournament progressed.

Patidar amassed 501 runs at a strike rate of 192.69, often arriving when games were delicately poised. There were innings where he rebuilt after early wickets and others where he immediately counterattacked.

He was hardly alone.

David knew exactly why he had been recruited. His brief was simple: finish games. He scored 305 runs at a strike rate of 189.44, repeatedly tipping balanced contests in RCB's favour. His unbeaten 70 off 25 balls against Chennai Super Kings stood out, but it was hardly an isolated contribution.

The pattern repeated itself throughout the season. An early wicket rarely derailed the innings. A collapse never seemed to be around the corner. If conditions became difficult, the batting order adapted. Rarely did the side look dependent on one individual. If the batting provided momentum, the bowlers rarely allowed opponents a way back into contests.

While the batting attracted much of the attention, RCB's attack quietly controlled games throughout the season. There were nights when Josh Hazlewood's relentless accuracy set the tone. On others, Bhuvneshwar Kumar's experience came to the fore. Jacob Duffy provided control, while Rasikh Salam Dar gradually evolved from a supporting act into a genuine match-winner.

There were evenings when the new ball swung extravagantly under lights and others when it resembled a piece of old leather from the very first over. If movement was available, they exploited it relentlessly. If it disappeared, they shifted gears, attacked hard lengths and squeezed scoring opportunities.

It was a bowling attack built not on mystery but on discipline.

The experience within the attack also created space for younger bowlers to grow.

Rasikh's emergence perhaps best illustrated the growth of the bowling unit. Trusted with difficult overs and frequently asked to operate under pressure, the young seamer grew in confidence as the tournament progressed. With Gujarat Titans threatening to build momentum, Rasikh struck at crucial moments and finished with figures of 3 for 27 in the final, effectively extinguishing hopes of a comeback.

Krunal's contribution was harder to measure. His influence rarely arrived with fanfare. Yet few players were more important to the balance of the side. Batters rarely scored freely against him. Dot balls accumulated. Pressure mounted. More often than not, his overs created the pressure that allowed the quicks to attack from the other end.

Much of the bowling unit's growth could be traced back to Omkar Salvi.

Having spent years immersed in domestic cricket for Mumbai, Salvi brought both technical expertise and a deep understanding of emerging talent. "You won't find him talking too much in meetings," Patidar said. "He spent a lot of time one-on-one with every bowler. That helped everyone."

As the weeks passed, the attack looked sharper, more adaptable and far more confident in different conditions. By the time the playoffs arrived, RCB was the most complete